

A.A.® Guidelines

Intergroup or Central Offices

from GSO, Box 459, Grand Central Station, New York, NY 10163

The A.A. Guidelines below are compiled from the shared service experience of A.A. members throughout the U.S. and Canada. They also reflect guidance given through the Twelve Traditions and the General Service Conference. In keeping with our Tradition of autonomy except in matters affecting other groups or A.A. as a whole, most decisions are made by the group conscience of the members involved. The purpose of these Guidelines is to assist in reaching an *informed* group conscience.

Local A.A. offices, often referred to as intergroups or central offices, have been around since the earliest years of A.A., even predating the general service conference structure. After our first A.A. office opened in the New York region, two more opened in Akron and Cleveland.

In some A.A. communities a central office is still the primary hub of local service work. In other parts, district committees that are part of the general service structure operate local service centers that carry out the functions of a typical central office. In still other parts of our Fellowship, an intergroup office and a general service committee work separately (but cooperatively) in carrying out the work of A.A. Like all of A.A., decisions about the operations of these vital entities are best left to local group conscience.

WHAT IS AN INTERGROUP OR CENTRAL OFFICE?

A central or intergroup office is an A.A. service entity that involves partnership among groups in a community — just as A.A. groups themselves are partnerships of individuals. An intergroup/central office is established to carry out certain functions common to all the groups — functions which are best handled by a centralized office — and it is usually maintained, supervised, and supported by these groups in their general interest. It exists to aid the groups in their common purpose of carrying the A.A. message to the alcoholic who still suffers.

FUNCTIONS OF AN INTERGROUP/CENTRAL OFFICE

A.A. experience has demonstrated that intergroup/central offices are helpful, particularly in populous areas. There are over 800 intergroup/central offices throughout the world, performing vital A.A. services. These constitute a network of service outlets and A.A. contacts to help carry the A.A. message.

The following suggestions outline the basic services an intergroup/central office might offer:

1. **A.A. Inquiries** — Because local A.A. offices are often the front door of A.A. to those seeking help, many central offices maintain easy-to-find websites, easy-to-navigate meeting lists, and hotlines staffed with sober A.A. members. They will refer the caller to a nearby A.A. group or meeting, where sponsorship may be arranged, or have a twelfth stepper contact them.

2. **Office Facilities** — The intergroup/central office can maintain a conveniently located office in which paid workers and/or volunteers coordinate local A.A. services.
3. **Meeting Lists and Other Literature** — At regular intervals, the intergroup/central office may publish and distribute up-to-date lists of meetings and other information about local A.A. services. Many intergroup/central offices sell AAWS and AA Grapevine literature for the convenience of local groups.
4. **Information Exchange** — The service office may function as a clearinghouse for the circulation and exchange of information among all the A.A. groups in the community. In this same connection, a logical function of the intergroup/central office is to provide “exchange” meetings, where group program chairpersons meet regularly to exchange meetings with other groups.
5. **Local Committees on Public Information (PI) and Cooperation with the Professional Community (CPC) in cooperation with district and area PI and CPC committees** — Because a central office is often the most visible and easy-to-find A.A. resource, it is frequently the first point of contact for professionals and the general public seeking information about A.A. Thus, A.A.’s relations with the public and professionals in the alcoholism field are often handled through the cooperation of general service committees and intergroup/central offices. To avoid duplication of efforts and other difficulties, good communication between all parts of A.A. is paramount. A.A. Guidelines and Workbooks on PI and CPC are available on GSO’s website at www.aa.org.
6. **A.A. in Correctional and Treatment Facilities** — The intergroup/central office can maintain contact with local groups in correctional facilities and treatment facilities, offering literature and prerelease A.A. contacts and arranging for A.A. speakers and visitors to meetings. When there is a corrections or treatment committee for this purpose, the service office may assist it through close cooperation with local hospitals and prisons.

Intergroup/central offices handling institutional contacts can find A.A. Guidelines and other service material on aa.org for shared experience in providing these services.

7. **Local A.A. Events** — An A.A. intergroup/central office is a logical body to manage the details of an annual dinner, picnic, or convention, if the participating groups wish it. See suggestions in MG-04 Conferences, Conventions and Roundups for A.A. experience with putting on an A.A. event.
8. **A.A. Bulletin or Newsletter** — The preparation of a publication for periodic distribution to A.A. groups is often a function of the intergroup/central office. Many offices save postage and increase distribution by using digital delivery as well.
9. **Accessibilities** — Many intergroup/central offices carry information on groups that are wheelchair accessible, or which may provide American Sign Language (ASL) interpretation for members who are Deaf. Some offices have equipment or materials for communicating with alcoholics who have visual and auditory challenges, those who are housebound or chronically ill, those who are living with the effects of brain damage or stroke, and others who may have less visible challenges. Some offices maintain lists of certified sign-language interpreters who are available for meetings or events.
10. **Website** — Many intergroups and central offices provide online chat services, offer digital A.A. materials in the languages of their communities, and use an ADA Accessible website format. When adding materials from aa.org to local websites be sure to use the weblinks instead of downloading PDFs. This will ensure the most recent versions of these materials.

MAKING A GOOD BEGINNING

Like many well-meant ventures in A.A., intergroup/central offices sometimes suffer because they are conceived and established without advance planning. The unhappy and damaging experiences of such ventures indicate that a few questions should be raised before an intergroup/central office is opened.

One question should concern actual need. Is there a sufficient number of groups in the community to justify opening an intergroup/central office? Is there a widely-expressed need? Has the potential impact on other local A.A. offices in the community been discussed? Are the groups willing and able to support such a service office financially? Have the groups been consulted as to whether such an office could address their specific service needs? Will they cooperate with and support a new office's aims and purposes? (If, after such consideration, an office seems impractical or not necessary at the time, a telephone answering service may fill the service needs of the community. If additional information is needed, GSO has Guidelines on A.A. Answering Services.)

Where Money and Spirituality Mix

(from the A.A. Guidelines on Finance):

"Members celebrate sobriety by giving time, energy, and money in support of our Twelfth Step — carrying the message — the basic service that the A.A. Fellowship offers.

Members assure that group expenses are paid by putting money into the basket passed at each meeting. It is each member's responsibility to support the services that have been requested by the A.A. Fellowship, to help facilitate A.A.'s vital Twelfth Step. Contributions are made in a spirit of sacrifice, and they honor A.A.'s code of "love and service." Contributions also underscore the spiritual nature of our Fellowship and our mutual love and trust. We have found that these contributions are as important to each member as they are to the service centers supported."

LOCATIONS

Questions should also be raised about proposed locations for the intergroup/central office and the personnel and equipment needed. It's sometimes tempting to consider moderately priced or free facilities supplied by agencies or organizations working in the field of alcoholism or in other fields. But it's better to forgo this short-term advantage if there's any likelihood that A.A. would lose its independent status in the bargain or appear — in the public mind at least — to be sponsored or controlled by the other organization.

The question also comes up whether to buy property or a building. A.A. traditionally does not own property, "lest problems of money, property and prestige divert us from our primary purpose." Experience also indicates that it is not fair or wise to commit future A.A. members to financial obligations for which they have not initially assumed responsibility, so renting a facility has proved best. It may also appear attractive to consolidate the intergroup/central office with the facilities and operations of a club. But the risks and pitfalls involved in this are almost too numerous to mention here. One reason for discouraging this is the possibility that the problems of operating the club and the service office will become intertwined, to the detriment of each activity. An even more important point is the need for keeping a clear separation between club operations and A.A. group activities; any strong identification with a club may impair an intergroup/central office's ability to serve the groups.

A central location for the office is usually desirable if finances permit. It's also prudent to take in possible future needs at the same time the original quarters are being considered; sometimes it's possible to rent facilities in buildings where adjoining rooms may become available later. Sufficient room should be provided for copying, mailings, committee meetings, and talking to newcomers. Since an intergroup/central office is intended to provide services for all A.A. groups in a community, experience indicates that it is best for the office not to give or rent space to any one group for meetings. The decision, however, is really up to each office, acting autonomously.

GROUP REPRESENTATION AT AN INTERGROUP/CENTRAL OFFICE

Service centers usually have no authority on their own account; they derive it from the participating groups. Intergroup/central

offices are A.A. service entities, and are “directly responsible to those they serve,” as described in Tradition Nine. Local group representatives participate in forming the group conscience that guides the service center operations.

In most communities, an intergroup/central office committee or steering committee is set up to handle the administrative activities of the service office. The steering committee holds regularly scheduled meetings and deals with general policy and plans. Periodically, the steering committee reports to group representatives on intergroup/central office problems and accomplishments. It is extremely important to keep a two-way flow of information going between the intergroup/central office and groups.

Getting Underway

Once some of the preliminary matters have been satisfactorily disposed of, the road is clear for the formal organizational work. Here’s a suggested plan that has worked well.

Each group in the community is asked to send both a representative and an alternate representative to a special meeting to form an intergroup/central office committee (also called a steering committee in some places). In large communities, it is sometimes necessary to divide the groups into zones, with a zone representative serving several groups. Once formed, the committee takes over the responsibility for the project and outlines its aims and purposes for approval by the participant groups. Such an outline might cover these points:

1. Listing of all groups in the community that want to participate.
2. A reminder that financial support is voluntary and not a condition of membership (in keeping with A.A. tradition).
3. A clear explanation that responsibility for the maintenance of the service office rests with the groups. Therefore, each group should name an intergroup/central office representative and an alternate to serve a specified term as the connecting link between the group and its intergroup/central office.
4. A summary of the functions of the intergroup/central office and an explanation of how it will be staffed and operated.
5. A discussion of how the service office will handle such vital matters as inquiries from newcomers, relations with the press, and similar duties.
6. Assurance that the service center will be operated in keeping with A.A.’s Twelve Traditions.

STAFFING THE INTERGROUP

Most A.A. intergroup/central offices now employ at least one paid full-time secretary or manager, as well as A.A. volunteers — members who respond to Twelfth Step calls at the office, answer the telephone, and often carry out other service office duties. Large offices may also have paid clerical workers on

the staff to assist the full-time person. Although the principles involving certain paid employees of service centers are now widely known in A.A., it is still helpful to review the appropriate A.A. Tradition at the time of opening a new service office. As it states in Tradition Eight: “Alcoholics Anonymous should remain forever nonprofessional, but our service centers may employ special workers.” It should be clear from this that the paid secretary functions as a paid employee of the central office — not as an A.A. member — during duty hours and is hired largely on the basis of professional skill.

Regarding compensation for paid workers, Bill W. writes in “Twelve Concepts for World Service” as follows: “We believe that each paid executive, staff member, or consultant should be recompensed in reasonable relation to the value of his or her similar services or abilities in the commercial world.” Like any paid professional position, additional benefits including insurance and paid time off are typically part of the compensation package. It is suggested that the intergroup/central office full-time secretary also be accorded a vote as well as a voice on the steering committee. This policy is successfully followed by A.A. World Services, Inc.: The staff coordinator — a paid employee as well as an A.A. member — also serves as a director and thus has a vote on policy matters.

SUPERVISION — MAKING THE OFFICE SERVE

It’s plain that the success of the intergroup/central office requires community-wide agreement on matters concerning administrative responsibility and authority. In keeping with Concept X’s suggestion that we clearly define a service position’s “scope of authority,” the steering committee should reach an early consensus on this; if necessary, they should explain it in the bylaws or some other set of guidelines. For, while it’s difficult to establish hard-and-fast rules and then live by them, it’s at least reasonable to clarify such matters as the functions of the office and the extent of the paid secretary’s authority and duties.

Some decisions can be entrusted to the paid secretary. In other cases, it may be wiser for the steering committee to maintain full oversight of many matters. In any case, it’s important that problems get an early review by someone who is authorized to deal with them and can solve them as quickly as possible. Otherwise, the service office operations are bound to suffer.

Special attention might be given to the following matters in the operation of the office:

1. Fair distribution of Twelfth Step calls. However tempting it may be to assign follow-up calls to those individuals and groups that seem especially willing, the Twelfth Step work is something all the groups in the community should be encouraged to share. But it’s also important that calls are distributed according to the location of the group; that is, newcomers should usually be put in touch with the group nearest to them.

2. After closing hours, A.A. volunteers or a telephone answering service — carefully chosen — should handle incoming calls. (See Guidelines on A.A. Answering Services.)
3. Authority and responsibility should be related. It is unfair to assign certain responsibilities to a paid secretary or volunteer without giving commensurate authority.

“Every trusted servant and every A.A. entity — at all levels of service — has the right ‘to decide . . . how they will interpret and apply their own authority and responsibility to each particular problem or situation as it arises.’ That is, they can ‘decide which problems they will dispose of themselves, and upon which matters they will report, consult, or ask specific directions.’ This is “the essence of ‘The Right of Decision.’”

(Twelve Concepts Illustrated, page 7)

FACING FINANCIAL RESPONSIBILITY

Incorporation: By its very nature, a service office involves making financial commitments quite different from those usually encountered in the operation of an A.A. group. Office facilities have to be leased; a secretary must be hired and paid; office supplies must be purchased; the telephone bill has to be paid regularly. To adequately take care of these responsibilities, it is generally wise to incorporate separately special facilities, such as a service office, which require money or management.

Since group purposes, local conditions, and state laws vary, it is suggested a local lawyer be consulted regarding such incorporation to explore appropriate non-profit tax status, any necessary tax filings, and the need for regular audits. At the same time, the following points might be emphasized: If possible, eliminate the name “Alcoholics Anonymous” from the corporate title. (This name is the sole property of A.A. as a whole.) Limit the activities of the corporation to the one locality only. Expenses create a need for financial responsibility that should be recognized at the outset; if properly understood and dealt with, it never need become a source of trouble.

Sometimes, however, intergroup/central office ventures have gotten caught up in disputes over money, authority, and like matters — thus becoming less effective in carrying the A.A. message. It’s not always clear why these troubles have come up, but often it’s been because the proper functions of an intergroup/central office were not clearly explained or understood, or there was some disregard of the principles in A.A.’s Twelve Traditions.

Suggested methods of financing an intergroup/central office:

1. **Group Collections.** A.A. groups participating in the financial support of the service office may choose to make their contributions by setting aside fixed sums from their regular collections. Many groups pledge a fixed amount, which is paid periodically. This assures the intergroup/central office of a regular income, and certainly helps it to plan the best means of meeting its own obligations.

Occasionally there are groups that do not support an intergroup/central office. In these cases, the spirit of contributing voluntarily, that prevails throughout A.A., applies. If groups can’t or choose not to pay their share of the costs, they shouldn’t be denied the services of the office.

2. **Special Contributions.** Some groups provide a special collection box or basket in a convenient place during meeting times, inviting members to contribute. In that same vein, A.A. members may make individual contributions, on a pledge or voluntary basis, directly to the service office. Also, many A.A.s make contributions to their intergroup/central office in celebration of their A.A. birthday or anniversary. Some offices accept electronic Seventh Tradition contributions through their websites. Some offices ask members to consider contributing \$5 per month (“Faithful Fivers”) or hold special drives during November, often referred to as “Gratitude Month.”
3. **Sale of Literature.** Many service offices publish their own meeting lists; others also produce introductory pamphlets explaining A.A. These can be sold at a slight profit to help defray office expenses. It is also possible to buy books from GSO for resale at the retail price, the profit going to support the intergroup/central office. The Conference-approved literature catalog describes various discounts. Central Offices should ensure they are complying with local, state or provincial tax laws if they choose to engage in retail literature sales.
4. **Special Events.** Some service offices hold yearly banquets, conventions, and similar events, using the “profits” for support of the office.

For help in financial planning, the 1977 General Service Conference recommended that “a suggested prudent reserve... preferably be one to 12 months’ operating expense, depending on local needs.”

INTERGROUP/CENTRAL OFFICES AND GSO

In 1986, the first Intergroup/Central Office/AAWS (ICOAA) Seminar was held to discuss questions on literature distribution, pricing and discounts, and to share ways to work together. Seminars are now held each year. Seminar history and information can be found at: www.icoaa.org.

For its own part, GSO also seeks to keep intergroup/central offices well informed. As a regular policy, the GSO newsletter, Box 4-5-9, as well as activity updates and AAWS Highlights, are sent to each intergroup/central office that lists itself with GSO. Additionally, advance notice is provided to intergroup/central offices when there are any planned discounts or price changes going into effect. Therefore, it is important to remember to update office contact information. The staff member on the Group Services assignment is the liaison with intergroup/central offices. You may contact Group Services by calling (212) 870-3287 or emailing groupservices@aa.org.

The common experience has shown that A.A.'s worldwide unity is best served if A.A. groups maintain their own separate contacts with GSO. Direct group contact with GSO doesn't take the place of services provided by a local service office, but helps GSO to keep in closer touch with all groups.

There are, however, some important areas of interest in which close contact between the intergroup/central offices and GSO is not only desirable but necessary. Some intergroup/central offices, for example, like to be provided with New Group Information Forms so that newly formed groups can be immediately listed with GSO. These forms as well as forms for changing group information, are available on aa.org.

Groups should not assume that if they list themselves with an intergroup/central office they are automatically listed at GSO. New groups are encouraged to send a Group Information Form directly to the General Service Office, P.O. Box 459, Grand Central Station, New York, NY 10163, or emailing memberservices@aa.org.

AAWS Meeting Guide App



Meeting Guide was started as a project to help members in Santa Clara County, CA. It launched in November 2015 with seven connected Intergroup/Central Office websites. Read more about the history of Meeting Guide in this article from the Fall 2019 issue of A.A.'s *Box 4-5-9* newsletter.

Meeting Guide syncs with area, district, intergroup/central offices and international General Service Office websites (those listed on A.A. Near You), relaying meeting information from more than 500 A.A. service entities directly to you. Nearly 150,000 weekly meetings are currently listed, and the information is refreshed twice daily. The app is used by more than 768,500 users every month.

The app gives A.A. service entities full control of their local meeting information while collecting it in one place, making it easy for anyone to find a meeting. Local entities provide their meeting information voluntarily. Meeting Guide users can suggest additions or corrections to meeting listings by using links provided within the app to contact the local service entity responsible for the information.

NEWSLETTERS OR BULLETINS

Newsletters or bulletins published by intergroup/central offices may include not only office news and events, but similar information about the groups and committees served by these offices (such as meeting times, openings of new groups, or changes of group meeting locations or officers). Frequently, material from A.A. literature is reprinted and discussed, and articles on subjects of interest to A.A.s also are published.

Experience indicates that, as in most A.A. service activities, it is prudent to make a committee (rather than one or two individuals)

responsible for the format, planning, and content of the bulletin. Many local publications quote from A.A. literature such as the Big Book, the Twelve and Twelve, *The A.A. Service Manual*, and Conference-approved pamphlets. Any A.A. newsletter, bulletin, or meeting list is more than welcome to use this material. Please be sure to include the proper credit line in your publications, in order to ensure that the copyrights of A.A. literature are protected.

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More suggestions you might consider, based on local experience with A.A. newsletters and bulletins.

- Scheduling a "theme issue," centering on some aspect of the A.A. program and using excerpts from Conference-approved material (with proper credit) relating to the theme.
- Asking for and publishing letters from your A.A. readers.
- Carrying highlights of minutes from various committee meetings — intergroup/central office steering committee, institutions, public information, etc.
- Including committee financial reports and records of group contributions.
- Running occasional appropriate cartoons. (If these are from the AA Grapevine or Conference-approved pamphlets, please remember that illustrations, too, are copyrighted, and the proper credit should accompany any of these that are used.)
- Running a "Calendar of Events" feature.
- Conducting a subscription campaign (perhaps making announcements at group meetings), to build paid readership.
- Check out GSO's "What's New" page on aa.org for the latest news from your GSO Office.

COMMUNICATION

Communication is the key to working together — Intergroup or Central Office and General Service Area Committee, the District Committee and the General Service Office of A.A. In 1990 the

General Service Conference stressed the importance of communication and recommended that delegates establish and maintain contact with offices in their areas to share Conference information and assure that intergroup/central offices have a voice in the Fellowship through their existing service structure.

Try to find out what is going on by getting together from time to time with corresponding committees in your area. It is important to share ideas and discuss activities so as to avoid duplication of effort. It is not important who does the work (the General Service Committee or the intergroup/central office Committee in your area) but that the work gets done — that help is there for the next alcoholic who needs us and our Fellowship.

Intergroup/central offices and general service area committees are complementary, rather than competitive, A.A. operations. Both exist to help insure A.A. unity and to fulfill A.A.'s primary purpose of carrying the message.

GOOD LUCK AND SMOOTH SAILING

We hope these suggestions will help make your central/intergroup office venture a vital and fruitful addition to the A.A. activity in your area. These are suggestions only, and it's the spirit and cooperation behind the central office idea that will make it work.

If you are starting a new office please write to GSO; your office will be added to the mailing list as well as

the "A.A. Near You" section of the aa.org website so that you may share A.A. experience with others and be available for any alcoholic seeking help.